城市里的一天

从早餐摊到夜市

A Day in a Chinese City

From the breakfast stall to the night market

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 王明[†]今年二十八岁，在杭州[‡]一家设计公司工作。他的生活和很多中国年轻人差不多：工作很忙，节奏[§]很快，手机从来不离手。下面，我们就跟着他，看看中国城市里普通的一天是什么样子的。

早上：一个煎饼[¶]

2 早上七点，王明的手机闹钟响了。他一边刷牙，一边看手机上的天气和新闻。今天天气不错，最高气温二十五度，没有雨。他很快地穿好衣服，拿上包，就出门了。

3 小区[*]门口有好几个早餐摊[#]，每天早上都很热闹。

† 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
‡ 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou, capital of Zhejiang
§ 节奏 *jiézòu* pace, rhythm
¶ 煎饼 *jiānbing* jianbing, Chinese breakfast crêpe
* 小区 *xiǎoqū* residential compound
\# 摊 *tān* stall

Wang Ming is twenty-eight and works at a design company in Hangzhou. 1
His life is much like that of many young Chinese people: work is busy, the pace is fast, and his phone never leaves his hand. Let's follow him and see what an ordinary day in a Chinese city looks like.

Morning: A Jianbing

At seven in the morning, the alarm on Wang Ming's phone goes off. While 2
he brushes his teeth, he checks the weather and the news on his phone. It's a fine day: a high of twenty-five degrees and no rain. He quickly gets dressed, grabs his bag and heads out.

At the gate of his residential compound there are several breakfast stalls, 3
and every morning the place is bustling.

3 有卖包子和豆浆[1]的，有卖煎饼[2]的，还有卖油条[3]的。王明[4]最喜欢一位阿姨做的煎饼：她把面糊[5]倒在铁板上，打一个鸡蛋，放一些葱花[6]和生菜，再卷起来，一分钟就做好了。

4 付钱的时候，王明不用拿钱包，只要拿出手机，扫一下摊位[7]上的二维码[8]就行了。在中国的城市里，手机支付已经非常普遍了。大家最常用的是微信和支付宝[9]，从大商场到路边的小摊[10]，几乎到处都可以扫码[11]。王明已经记不清楚自己上一次用现金是什么时候了。不过，也有一些老人还是习惯用现金，所以很多商店两种方式都接受。

5 菜市场[12]里也是这样。王明有时候周末去买菜，会看到一位七十多岁的老奶奶在卖自己种的青菜。

1 豆浆 *dòujiāng* soy milk
2 煎饼 *jiānbing* jianbing, Chinese breakfast crêpe
3 油条 *yóutiáo* fried dough stick
4 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
5 面糊 *miànhú* batter
6 葱花 *cōnghuā* chopped scallions
7 摊位 *tānwèi* stall
8 二维码 *èrwéimǎ* QR code
9 支付宝 *Zhīfùbǎo* Alipay
10 摊 *tān* stall
11 扫码 *sǎomǎ* to scan a QR code
12 菜市场 *càishìchǎng* food market

One sells steamed buns and soy milk, another sells jianbing, another fried dough sticks. His favourite is the jianbing made by one auntie: she pours batter onto the hotplate, cracks an egg over it, adds some chopped scallions and lettuce, rolls it up, and in a minute it's ready. 3

When it's time to pay, Wang Ming doesn't need his wallet: he just takes out his phone and scans the QR code at the stall. In Chinese cities, paying by phone has become extremely common. The apps people use most are WeChat and Alipay, and almost everywhere, from big shopping malls to small roadside stalls, you can pay by scanning a code. Wang Ming can no longer remember the last time he used cash. Still, some older people are used to cash, so many shops accept both. 4

It's the same at the food market. Sometimes when Wang Ming goes grocery shopping at the weekend, he sees an old lady in her seventies selling greens she grew herself. 5

她的菜篮子上也挂着一张二维码[1]，是她的孙子帮她申请的。每次有人付了钱，她的手机就会用很大的声音报出收到了多少钱，这样她不用戴眼镜也知道。

上班路上

王明[2]家离地铁站有一公里多。他一般不走路，而是骑共享单车[3]过去。路边停着很多不同颜色的自行车，用手机扫一下车上的二维码，锁[4]就自动打开了。骑到地铁站只要五分钟，费用也很便宜，一般一两块钱。到了以后，把车停在画好的区域[5]里，再关上锁就可以了。

早上八点左右是早高峰[6]，地铁里人特别多。进站以前，每个人的包都要经过安检[7]。

1 二维码 *èrwéimǎ* QR code
2 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
3 共享单车 *gòngxiǎng dānchē* shared bike
4 锁 *suǒ* lock
5 区域 *qūyù* area, zone
6 早高峰 *zǎogāofēng* morning rush hour
7 安检 *ānjiǎn* security check

A QR code hangs on her vegetable basket too; her grandson set it up for her. 5
Every time someone pays, her phone announces loudly how much money has come in, so she knows without having to put on her glasses.

On the Way to Work

Wang Ming's home is a little over a kilometre from the metro station. Instead 6
of walking, he usually rides a shared bike there. Bikes of different colours are parked along the street; scan the QR code on one with your phone and the lock opens by itself. Riding to the station takes only five minutes, and it's cheap too, usually a yuan or two. When you arrive, you park the bike inside the marked area, close the lock, and that's it.

Around eight in the morning is rush hour, and the metro is packed. Before 7
entering the station, everyone's bag goes through a security check.

7 王明[1]用手机在闸机[2]上刷一下，就进了站。车厢[3]里很挤[4]，但是很安静：几乎每个人都低着头看手机，有的看短视频[5]，有的看小说，有的在回复工作消息。王明戴上耳机，听了一会儿英语播客，二十分钟以后就到了公司附近的那一站。

在公司

8 王明的公司在一座高楼的十八层。九点上班以前，他先在楼下的咖啡店买了一杯咖啡。他是在手机上提前点的，到店里拿了就走，不用排队。这几年，喝咖啡的中国年轻人越来越多了，不过很多人下午还是更喜欢喝奶茶。

9 上午十点，部门开了一个短会。王明的同事小张[6]没有来，因为她今天去上海[7]见客户[8]了。

1 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
2 闸机 *zhájī* ticket gate
3 车厢 *chēxiāng* train carriage
4 挤 *jǐ* crowded
5 短视频 *duǎnshìpín* short videos
6 小张 *Xiǎo Zhāng* Xiao Zhang, a colleague
7 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
8 客户 *kèhù* client

Wang Ming taps his phone on the ticket gate and he's in. The carriage is crowded but quiet: almost everyone is looking down at a phone, some watching short videos, some reading novels, some answering work messages. Wang Ming puts on his earphones and listens to an English podcast for a while; twenty minutes later he reaches the stop near his office. 7

At the Office

Wang Ming's company is on the eighteenth floor of a tall building. Before work starts at nine, he buys a coffee at the café downstairs. He ordered it ahead on his phone, so he just picks it up and goes, without queuing. In recent years more and more young Chinese people drink coffee, although many still prefer milk tea in the afternoon. 8

At ten the department holds a short meeting. His colleague Xiao Zhang isn't there, because she has gone to Shanghai today to meet a client. 9

9 她早上坐高铁去，从杭州[1]到上海[2]不到一个小时，晚上还能回来吃晚饭。买火车票也很方便，在手机上选好车次和座位，进站的时候刷身份证就可以了。小张[3]在会上通过视频[4]跟大家打了个招呼，她身后的车窗外，田野[5]正在飞快地往后退。

10 中午十二点，办公室里开始讨论一个重要的问题：午饭吃什么？公司附近有不少餐厅[6]，但是很多人还是选择点外卖。打开外卖软件[7]，可以看到几百家饭店，米饭、面条、饺子、麻辣烫[8]，什么都有。王明[9]点了一份牛肉面，手机上显示，外卖员[10]会在三十分钟内送到。他在地图上能看到外卖员骑着电动车，一点一点地靠近[11]。二十五分钟后，面就放在了公司的前台[12]，还是热的。

1 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou, capital of Zhejiang
2 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
3 小张 *Xiǎo Zhāng* Xiao Zhang, a colleague
4 视频 *shìpín* video
5 田野 *tiányě* fields
6 餐厅 *cāntīng* restaurant
7 软件 *ruǎnjiàn* app, software
8 麻辣烫 *málàtàng* malatang, spicy pick-and-mix soup
9 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
10 外卖员 *wàimàiyuán* delivery rider
11 靠近 *kàojìn* to approach
12 前台 *qiántái* reception desk

She took the high-speed train this morning: Hangzhou to Shanghai takes less than an hour, so she'll still be back in time for dinner. Buying train tickets is easy too: you choose the train and your seat on your phone, then swipe your ID card when you enter the station. Xiao Zhang says hello to everyone over video during the meeting; through the train window behind her, fields are rushing past. 9

At noon the office starts discussing an important question: what to have for lunch? There are plenty of restaurants near the office, but many people still choose to order delivery. Open the delivery app and you can see hundreds of restaurants: rice dishes, noodles, dumplings, malatang — everything you can think of. Wang Ming orders a bowl of beef noodles, and his phone says the rider will deliver it within thirty minutes. On the map he can watch the rider on an electric scooter getting closer bit by bit. Twenty-five minutes later the noodles are waiting at the reception desk, still hot. 10

11 吃完午饭，有的同事趴[1]在桌子上睡一会儿，有的出去散步。下午的工作比较多，王明[2]要修改一个设计方案，还要在网上跟客户[3]开会。三点多的时候，一位同事在工作群里发了个消息，问有没有人想一起点奶茶，一下子[4]就有七八个人回复了。六点下班的时候，天已经快黑了。

晚上的城市

12 王明回到小区[5]的时候，旁边的小公园里已经响起了音乐。几十个阿姨站成整齐的几排，正在跳广场舞[6]。她们大多已经退休了，每天晚上都在这里跳一个小时，既能锻炼身体，又能跟朋友聊天。王明的妈妈在老家也跳广场舞，还常常把跳舞的视频[7]发给他看。

1 趴 *pā* to lie face down
2 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
3 客户 *kèhù* client
4 一下子 *yīxiàzi* all at once
5 小区 *xiǎoqū* residential compound
6 广场舞 *guǎngchǎngwǔ* square dancing
7 视频 *shìpín* video

After lunch, some colleagues nap for a while with their heads on their desks, and others go out for a walk. The afternoon is busier: Wang Ming has a design proposal to revise and an online meeting with a client. A little after three, a colleague posts in the work group chat to ask whether anyone wants to order milk tea together, and seven or eight people reply at once. By the time work finishes at six, it is already getting dark. 11

The City at Night

By the time Wang Ming gets back to his compound, music is already playing in the little park next door. Dozens of middle-aged women stand in neat rows, doing "square dancing". Most of them are retired and dance here for an hour every evening; it keeps them fit and lets them chat with friends. Wang Ming's mother does square dancing in his hometown too, and often sends him videos of her dancing. 12

12 当然，也有邻居[1]觉得音乐太吵，所以很多公园对跳舞的时间和音量[2]有一些要求。

13 吃晚饭以前，王明[3]在买菜软件[4]上下了个订单[5]：西红柿[6]、鸡蛋、青菜和一盒[7]牛奶。不到半个小时，骑手[8]就把东西送到了门口。他做了一个简单的西红柿炒鸡蛋[9]，又煮[10]了一锅[11]米饭。小区[12]门口的快递柜[13]里还有一个他前天网购的包裹。他下楼输入取件码[14]，柜门[15]就自己打开了。

14 吃饭的时候，王明看到小张[16]在工作群里发了一张照片：她已经坐上了回杭州[17]的高铁，小桌子上放着一盒在上海[18]买的点心[19]。她说，明天把点心带到公司，请大家吃。

1 邻居 *línjū* neighbour
2 音量 *yīnliàng* volume
3 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
4 软件 *ruǎnjiàn* app, software
5 订单 *dìngdān* order
6 西红柿 *xīhóngshì* tomato
7 盒 *hé* box, carton
8 骑手 *qíshǒu* delivery rider
9 西红柿炒鸡蛋 *xīhóngshì chǎo jīdàn* tomato-and-egg stir-fry
10 煮 *zhǔ* to cook (by boiling)
11 锅 *guō* pot
12 小区 *xiǎoqū* residential compound
13 快递柜 *kuàidìguì* parcel locker
14 取件码 *qǔjiànmǎ* pickup code
15 柜门 *guìmén* locker door
16 小张 *Xiǎo Zhāng* Xiao Zhang, a colleague
17 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou, capital of Zhejiang
18 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
19 点心 *diǎnxin* pastries, snacks

Of course, some neighbours find the music too loud, so many parks set rules about dancing times and volume. 12

Before dinner, Wang Ming places an order on a grocery app: tomatoes, eggs, greens and a carton of milk. In less than half an hour, a rider has brought everything to his door. He cooks a simple tomato-and-egg stir-fry and a pot of rice. In the parcel locker at the compound gate there is also a package he bought online two days ago. He goes downstairs, enters the pickup code, and the locker door opens by itself. 13

While eating, Wang Ming sees that Xiao Zhang has posted a photo in the work group: she's already on the high-speed train back to Hangzhou, with a box of pastries from Shanghai on the little table. She says she'll bring them to the office tomorrow for everyone. 14

14 一天之内[1]去另[2]一个城市开会，再回来睡在自己的床上，在高铁出现以前，这是很难想象的。

15 吃完饭，王明[3]给老家的父母打了一个视频[4]电话。爸爸问他最近工作忙不忙，妈妈问他有没有好好吃饭。他把手机对着桌子，让妈妈看他做的西红柿炒鸡蛋[5]。妈妈笑着说："鸡蛋炒[6]得太老了，下次火小一点。"他们聊[7]了半个小时，最后妈妈又提醒他早点睡觉。

16 晚上八点，一个大学同学发消息约他去逛夜市[8]。夜市在一条老街上，两边都是小吃摊[9]，空气里都是烧烤[10]的香味[11]。他们买了烤鱿鱼[12][13]、臭豆腐[14]和一杯鲜榨果汁[15]，一边走一边吃。

1 之内 *zhīnèi* within
2 另 *lìng* another
3 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
4 视频 *shìpín* video
5 西红柿炒鸡蛋 *xīhóngshì chǎo jīdàn* tomato-and-egg stir-fry
6 炒 *chǎo* to stir-fry
7 聊 *liáo* to chat
8 夜市 *yèshì* night market
9 小吃摊 *xiǎochītān* snack stall
10 烧烤 *shāokǎo* barbecue
11 香味 *xiāngwèi* aroma
12 烤 *kǎo* grilled
13 鱿鱼 *yóuyú* squid
14 臭豆腐 *chòudòufu* stinky tofu
15 鲜榨 *xiānzhà* freshly squeezed

Going to another city for a meeting and sleeping in your own bed the same night was hard to imagine before high-speed rail. 14

After dinner, Wang Ming makes a video call to his parents back home. His father asks whether work has been busy lately, and his mother asks whether he's been eating properly. He points the phone at the table so his mother can see the tomato-and-egg stir-fry he made. His mother laughs: "You've overcooked the eggs. Use a lower heat next time." They chat for half an hour, and at the end his mother reminds him, once again, to go to bed early. 15

At eight, a university friend messages him to go to the night market. The night market is on an old street lined with snack stalls on both sides, and the air is full of the smell of barbecue. They buy grilled squid, stinky tofu and a cup of freshly squeezed juice, and eat as they walk. 16

16 臭豆腐[1]闻起来很臭[2]，吃起来却很香，第一次吃的外国游客常常吓一跳[3]。很多年轻人一边逛一边拍照，把照片发到朋友圈[4]里。

17 回到家，已经十点多了。王明[5]洗了个澡，躺在床上，打开手机看了看今天的账单[6]。早饭、单车、地铁、咖啡、午饭、奶茶、买菜、夜市[7]……一天下来，他一次也没有打开过钱包。他设[8]好明天早上七点的闹钟，放下手机，很快就睡着了。

结语

18 王明的一天很普通，但是从中可以看到中国城市生活的很多特点：快、方便，很多事情一部手机就能解决。当然，这种方便也带来了一些问题。

1 臭豆腐 *chòudòufu* stinky tofu
2 臭 *chòu* smelly
3 吓一跳 *xià yī tiào* to get a fright
4 朋友圈 *péngyouquān* WeChat Moments
5 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
6 账单 *zhàngdān* bill, statement
7 夜市 *yèshì* night market
8 设 *shè* to set

Stinky tofu smells terrible but tastes delicious; foreign visitors trying it for the first time are often taken aback. Many young people take photos as they stroll and post them on their WeChat Moments. 16

By the time he gets home it is past ten. Wang Ming takes a shower, lies down in bed and opens his phone to look at today's spending. Breakfast, bike, metro, coffee, lunch, milk tea, groceries, the night market... in the whole day he never once opened his wallet. He sets his alarm for seven tomorrow morning, puts down his phone and soon falls asleep. 17

In Closing

Wang Ming's day is very ordinary, but it shows many features of city life in China: it is fast and convenient, and many things can be done with nothing more than a phone. Of course, this convenience also brings some problems. 18

18 对不太会用智能手机[1]的老人来说，有些事情反而变得更难了；外卖员[2]为了按时送到，每天在路上跑来跑去，工作非常辛苦[3]。同时，小区[4]门口的早餐摊[5]、公园里的广场舞[6]和热闹的夜市[7]，又让这座现代的城市保留着很多传统的味道。如果你有机会去中国，不妨[8]也像王明[9]一样，从一个煎饼[10]开始你的一天。

1 智能手机 *zhìnéng shǒujī* smartphone
2 外卖员 *wàimàiyuán* delivery rider
3 辛苦 *xīnkǔ* hard, exhausting
4 小区 *xiǎoqū* residential compound
5 摊 *tān* stall
6 广场舞 *guǎngchǎngwǔ* square dancing
7 夜市 *yèshì* night market
8 不妨 *bùfáng* might as well
9 王明 *Wáng Míng* Wang Ming (a name)
10 煎饼 *jiānbing* jianbing, Chinese breakfast crêpe

For older people who aren't comfortable with smartphones, some things have actually become harder; and delivery riders, racing to arrive on time, spend all day dashing around the city in a very demanding job. At the same time, the breakfast stalls at the compound gate, the square dancing in the park and the lively night markets keep much of the traditional flavour alive in this modern city. If you ever get the chance to go to China, why not do as Wang Ming does, and start your day with a jianbing? 18